



AI predicts Parkinson growth

IBM's AI can predict how Parkinson's disease may progress in individuals. <https://dgit.in/aug21-49>



Argo AI offers self-driving rides

Ford backed company, Argo AI can now offer the public rides in its autonomous vehicles. <https://dgit.in/aug21-50>

Nothing Ear 1

A masterclass in design under a budget

Ex OnePlus co-founder, Carl Pei's new venture "Nothing" has generated quite a bit of buzz in the tech community. The first product from the company is the Nothing Ear 1. The device has caused a stir in the market due to its transparent design. Let's put the TWS through its paces and find out if they are worth the hype, and your money.

BUILD AND COMFORT

If you're looking for TWS earbuds that stand out from the crowd, the Nothing Ear 1 does that exceedingly well. The transparent body of the case, while made out of plastic, looks deceptively like glass and Nothing claims that the material won't degrade or turn yellow over time. The earbuds, while not completely transparent, look extremely interesting. The stem portion of the buds is transparent and you can see a considerable number of components within the buds including the microphones, magnets, and even some silicone. The charging case houses the USB-C charging port and the pairing button on the right side and a pretty sizable indent on the top of the case to assist with opening it up.

The earbuds twist and lock securely in place and create a very snug and comfortable fit. The fit is extremely secure and doesn't budge in the slightest even when moving your head about frantically. It has an IPX4 rating which ensures that the buds can shrug off sweat and light splashes.

FEATURES

The Nothing Ear 1 is a pretty feature-laden pair of true wireless earphones under 6K. Let's start with the headlining feature Active Noise Cancellation. The Nothing Ear 1 does a fairly good job at blocking out low-end, constant ambient sounds such as the



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hum of an AC, the drone of an airplane, and more. It will not drown out higher-pitch or erratic sounds. The device also comes with Transparent Mode that amplifies ambient noise, so you can hear your surroundings. ANC and Transparency Mode aside, you have the Ear 1 app that allows users to tweak some settings on these earbuds. It can also be used to customise the touch controls, although the options are fairly limited here.

There's no voice assistant command on these buds which is frankly, baffling, seeing that some TWS under 2K also implement this feature.

Apart from touch controls, you can also switch between noise cancellation profiles within the Ear 1 app and choose between four preset EQ settings – Balanced, More Treble, More Bass, and Voice. There's no custom EQ setting, but owing to its low price point, we don't really expect one.

You also have the in-ear detection feature that uses sensors within the earbuds to pause the music automatically when removed from the ear, and play it when reinserted in the ear. This worked okay, however, there was a slight delay between removing the buds and the music actually pausing.

PERFORMANCE

The Nothing Ear 1 sports a 11.6mm dynamic driver. It supports SBC and AAC codecs. For a single driver setup, these earbuds have a pretty decent

sound signature. The buds have a V-shaped sound signature where the lows and highs are slightly accentuated in comparison to the mids. The bass is slightly exaggerated, but despite this it didn't sound muddy or boomy at any point. The mids are mostly in line with the ideal flat response, however, the exaggerated bass response can cause some auditory masking in the mids. The Nothing Ear 1 has a fairly pleasing sound signature that works well with genres such as pop, rap, EDM, hip hop, Bollywood, and even rock, to some extent.

BATTERY LIFE

The company claims that the buds have a playtime of 5.7 hours on the buds and 34 hours in total with the charging case, without ANC turned on. If you do turn it on at all times, the company claims 4 hours of playtime on the buds alone, and 24 hours in total with the charging case. We kept the ANC on at all times when we were testing battery life. In our tests, the buds lasted 3 hours and 40 minutes at 70 percent volume. The charging case was able to top off the earbuds 5 times over before needing to be charged. You also have Qi wireless charging support.

VERDICT

The Nothing Ear 1 is a masterclass in design, especially when it comes to earphones that don't burn a hole in your pocket. Priced under 6K, the Nothing Ear 1 is also a feature-packed pair of TWS earbuds, although there are some issues such as lack of voice assistant support, and auditory masking in the mids. Despite these shortcomings, the Nothing Ear 1 is one of the most well-rounded TWS you can find under 6K.

—Dhriti Datta

SPECIFICATIONS

WEIGHT: 47 grams (earbud), 57.4 grams (charging case) | DRIVER: 11.6 mm Dynamic | DIAPHRAGM: Graphene | TUNING: Teenage Engineering | CODEC: AAC and SBC | BATTERY: Full charge: Up to 34 hrs in the case (ANC Off); 24 hrs (ANC On) | BLUETOOTH VERSION: v5.2 | MICROPHONE: Triple High Definition Microphone setup

CONTACT

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